Article 7 proceedings against Hungary to address systemic violations of democratic principles, though the process remains fraught with political hurdles.

Beyond targeting Orbán directly via sidelining, the EU has sought to engage Hungarian citizens through public outreach. The Annual European Commission reports highlight Hungary's rule-of-law deficiencies,[12] while European Parliament resolutions call for the protection of democratic norms and civil liberties.[13] EU leaders, including the presidents of the European Commission and European Council, frequently address Hungary's actions in public statements and press briefings, aiming to foster transparency and accountability.[14] These efforts extend to the EU's broader electorate, as demonstrated by the New Pact on Migration and Asylum in 2023, which tightened migration policies to counter populist sentiment ahead of European Parliamentary elections.[15]

Finally, negotiations with Orbán often take place behind the scenes, out of view of Hungary's citizens. This ensures that Orbán does not face political blowback and gives him the political space to make compromises. In this way, the EU often sidelines Hungary's population from policy discussions.[16]

The EU's responses have thus far helped to retain Hungary's participation within the bloc and secure Orbán's support on key initiatives. However, these strategies come at a cost. Critics argue that appeasement undermines the EU's legitimacy by enabling Orbán to shape its agenda while simultaneously weaponizing EU policies for domestic political gain (Kelemen 2020). For instance, Orbán has framed the EU's conditionality measures as "political blackmail,"[17] using them to rally support among Hungarian voters.[18]

While the EU's resilience in navigating Orbán's challenges is evident, the long-term implications of these strategies remain uncertain. The delicate balance between appeasing disruptive leaders and sidelining their influence underscores the broader challenges the EU faces in upholding its norms while maintaining unity in an era of rising populism.